chapter, 'Maximum Leader', details how India reluctantly accepted Karzai's presidency. Moving away from the so-called 'proxy format' of the 1990s, to the dismay of its UF allies, New Delhi threw its weight behind Karzai. The eighth chapter, 'No Good Taliban?', shows how India's security calculus was disturbed when the Taliban made a decisive comeback and the political will of the coalition forces went into a collective decline in Afghanistan. The debate between the partisans and the conciliators became acute in New Delhi when the realisation dawned that the Taliban was to stay, and its sponsor, Pakistan, would not relent under international pressure. The ninth chapter, 'First as Tragedy, Then as Farce', shows how India dealt with the US withdrawal and the continuously failing reconciliation process with the Afghan Taliban. With regional and international postures evolving, India's Afghanistan policy came to be dominated by the conciliators after 2010, but remained fierce in its determination to steer the course of reconciliation in Kabul's favour.